

Spaced practice and retrieval in MBA Rock.

Why the curriculum is paced — and
why every lesson ends with a quiz.

RESEARCH BRIEF · DESIGN PILLAR 2

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Why the curriculum is paced across 74 lessons — and why every lesson ends with a quiz.

Two of the most-replicated findings in cognitive psychology

The **spacing effect** — better long-term retention from distributed study sessions than from equivalent massed sessions — is among the most robust findings in cognitive psychology. First documented by Ebbinghaus (1885/1913), it has been systematically reviewed in Cepeda et al. (2006), a meta-analysis of more than 800 quantitative comparisons. Cepeda et al. (2008) mapped optimal inter-study intervals as a function of the retention delay being targeted.

The **testing effect** — better long-term retention from retrieval practice than from additional re-study time — was demonstrated in a series of controlled experiments by Roediger and Karpicke (2006). Karpicke and Roediger (2008) followed up with evidence that retrieval practice produces durable retention gains across a wide range of materials and learner populations. Both effects have since been replicated repeatedly.

These findings are not aesthetic preferences. They are, taken together, among the strongest empirical recommendations the learning sciences offer for curriculum design.

How MBA Rock operationalizes both

Spacing. MBA Rock is structured as 74 self-paced lessons grouped into 10 modules. Lessons are intentionally bite-sized (typically 15–30 minutes of engagement each) and the platform is designed to be returned to, not binged. Cohort-paced versions for institutional partners distribute lessons across the academic calendar to implement spacing at the program level.

Retrieval. Every lesson ends with a short mastery quiz that requires the learner to actively retrieve the lesson's core concept from memory. Every lesson also presents a *take action* prompt — a deliberate application of the framework to the learner's own business — which functions as a second retrieval episode. The output of the take-action prompt then flows into the Capstone Dossier section for the corresponding module, creating a third deliberate retrieval episode as the learner integrates the framework into the larger business plan.

The desirable-difficulties case

Bjork and Bjork (2011) coined the phrase *desirable difficulties* for techniques — spacing, retrieval, interleaving — that feel harder during learning but produce stronger long-term retention than easier alternatives. The MBA Rock design is, in effect, a build-out of desirable difficulties: distributed lessons rather than crammed delivery, retrieval-based quizzes rather than re-watching, applied capstone work rather than passive completion.

What this means for institutional partners. Curricula that incorporate spacing and retrieval by design are predicted by the empirical literature to produce stronger long-term retention than otherwise-equivalent curricula that do not. Institutions adopting MBA Rock therefore offer their learners a design that is research-aligned by default, with the documented mechanisms (spacing, retrieval, desirable difficulties) built into the curriculum's structural architecture rather than left to learner discretion.

References

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